

Imagine a gorgeous tomboy, born to a mother who had rebelled against her own arranged marriage, educated at Santiniketan and Lausanne, Switzerland, brought up in the westernised environment typical of the royal Cooch Behar family, trained to kill tigers and ride horses, choosing to become the third wife of a feudal maharaja. Maharani Gayatri Devi to all who admired her grace and Ayesha to her friends, she was that rare and beautiful creature who was without vanity. But never without courage. She saw her husband, Maharaja Man Singh, with whom she had fallen in love when she was 12 and he 21, fall to his death while at a polo match at Cirencester in 1970; in 1975, she was imprisoned during the Emergency for her opposition to the Congress party; and in 1997, she lost her only child, Jagat Singh. She was the first princess to stand for Parliament, was elected thrice, and genuinely felt for Jaipur, up to her last days when she insisted she be flown down from London in an air ambulance because she was

## OBITUARY

## The Iconic Royal



THE HINDUSTAN TIMES

**Gayatri Devi**  
1919-2009

homesick. Through the abolition of the privy purse in 1971, prolonged court cases, and slights from successive governments who refused to let her install a statue of her

beloved Jai, as she called her husband, she kept her dignity intact. Photographed by the legendary Cecil Beaton in 1943, she was repeatedly named one of the most beautiful women in the world, but style to her was never an object of display. Her clothes had to do with rites of passage, remnants of a life fully lived, not material acquisitions—her trousseau, for instance, had sheets from Florence, shoes and bags from Ferragamo, nightgowns in mousseline de soie from Paris and saris embroidered in gold. She left life the way she lived it, despite a painful knee surgery. She was involved in two girls schools, most prominently, the Maharani Gayatri Devi School; was always vocal about politics; fanatical about polo; particular about the people she socialised with; and Jaipur's most gracious hostess, holding court in Lilypool that her husband built after their first home, Rambagh Palace, was transformed into a hotel. In her death, India has lost a royal icon and a stylish witness to almost a century of change. **by Rohit Parihar**

## FILM REVIEW

LUCK

## Luckless Viewers

Director: Soham Shah

Starring: Imran Khan, Sanjay Dutt, Shruti Hassan

RATING ★ ★ ☆ ☆ ☆

*Jinke paas luck nahin hai, woh usse aazmana chahte hain. Aur jinke paas luck hai, woh usse darte hain.* Drum roll. Applause expected. There are several such moments in *Luck*, which is a sort of paint-by-numbers thriller, where there is a hot chick, a pretty boy, a damaged guy, a psychotic dude and a dark shadowy mafia-type

character, usually played by Sanjay Dutt. There are item songs, at least one bikini shot, and train blow-ups. There is also the by-now mandatory skydiving sequence and an underwater segment with sharks. Imagine a *Khatron ke Khiladi* with movie actors or *Dhoom-2* with B-list stars. The dialogue seems to have been written by a committee which has read all the formulaic thrillers in the history of Bollywood and the director seems to have a check-

list of all the locations he wanted. He got them. It has deserts, mountains, a forest and a sea. It also has the sort of industrial music that Salim-Sulaiman are now familiar for—thumping beats, loud singing, and mindless lyrics repeated endlessly. A movie as empty as it is noisy.

**by Kaveree Bamzai**